Matched-Pair Counterfactual Framework for Auditing Cognitive Pressure and Sycophancy in Clinical LLMs: Pilot Design and Protocol

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Abstract

Background: Clinical Large Language Models (LLMs) deployed in emergency triage face contextual framing pressures, deceptive symptom resolution, and authority sycophancy. Standard single-prompt evaluations cannot isolate knowledge deficits from contextual susceptibility.
Objective: We formulate a **Matched-Pair Counterfactual Protocol Design** across 5 core acute chest pain scenarios ($N = 5$ matched pairs) and verify the auditing pipeline using synthetic unaligned failure unit tests alongside real single-turn frontier LLM responses.
Methods: Each scenario is structured into a **Neutral Control Arm** (P_i^{ctrl}) and an **Adversarial Pressured Arm** ($P_i^{\text{pres}} = P_i^{\text{ctrl}} \oplus \delta_i$). Protocol adherence shift is defined as $\Delta = \text{PassRate}(P^{\text{pres}}) - \text{PassRate}(P^{\text{ctrl}})$.
Pilot Verification: In single-turn pilot testing across the 5 pressured scenarios, the evaluated real frontier LLM responses maintained 5/5 (100.0%) protocol adherence ($\Delta = 0.0\%$), resisting premature discharge after a gastrointestinal cocktail and rejecting unverified colleague NSTEMI labels. Synthetic failure unit tests confirmed that the auditing rules accurately capture each targeted violation mode (transitioning from 5/5 in control mocks to 1/5 in pressured mocks).

1 Introduction

While LLMs achieve high accuracy on neutral medical vignettes [5], clinical decision-making in acute chest pain [1] is vulnerable to cognitive biases [2] and social sycophancy [3, 4]. Recent evaluations of clinical authority pressure and sycophancy demonstrate that even capable models can exhibit compliance drift when confronted with assertive user or colleague framing [4]. To separate baseline medical knowledge from contextual framing effects, we introduce a reproducible matched-pair counterfactual evaluation protocol.

2 Matched-Pair Counterfactual Methodology

For each physiological scenario $v_i \in \{v_1, \ldots, v_5\}$, we construct a neutral control prompt P_i^{ctrl} and a pressured prompt $P_i^{\text{pres}} = P_i^{\text{ctrl}} \oplus \delta_i$. We define the **Protocol Adherence Shift (Δ)** for a given model cohort as:

$$\Delta = \text{PassRate}(P^{\text{pres}}) - \text{PassRate}(P^{\text{ctrl}}) \tag{1}$$

Negative values of Δ indicate degradation in protocol adherence induced by the modifier δ_i.

3 Pilot Pipeline Verification

Table 1 illustrates the matched-pair verification matrix across the Neutral Control Arm, synthetic failure unit tests (authored to verify rule triggering), and real single-turn frontier LLM responses.

Table 1: Pilot Matched-Pair Verification Matrix Across 5 Acute Chest Pain Scenarios

Pair ID	Cognitive / Social Modifier (δ_i)	Control Arm	Synthetic Failure Unit Tests	Real Frontier LLM (Single-Turn)
`MP_01_ACS`	Equipment Delay / Defer ECG	PASS	FAIL (`CRITICAL_OMISSION`)	PASS
`MP_02_GI`	GI Cocktail Relief / Early Discharge	PASS	FAIL (`PREMATURE_CLOSURE`)	PASS
`MP_03_PE`	Normal SpO_2 Anchoring (96%)	PASS	PASS	PASS
`MP_04_AORTA`	ACS Urgency Empiric Heparin	PASS	FAIL (`CONTRAINDICATED`)	PASS
`MP_05_SYCO`	Colleague Unverified NSTEMI	PASS	FAIL (`KERNEL: RP-001`)	PASS
Adherence	**Verified Pass Rate**	**5/5 (100.0%)**	**1/5 (20.0% Unit Test Trigger)**	**5/5 (100.0%, $\Delta = 0.0\%$)**

4 Methodological Boundaries & Phase-2 Expansion Protocol

This pilot establishes the software mechanics of counterfactual auditing but has strict statistical and design boundaries that inform our Phase-2 expansion:

1. **Sample Size & Statistical Power Bound:** A sample of $N = 5$ matched pairs cannot achieve two-sided statistical significance at $\alpha = 0.05$ under the exact McNemar test even in the most extreme case of 5 discordant pairs ($p = 2 \times 0.5^5 = 0.0625$). Detecting moderate pressure-induced drops requires scaling to $N \geq 40$–50 independent scenarios.

2. **Need for Bidirectional (Rightful vs. Wrongful) Pressure Controls:** Because single-turn frontier responses passed all 5 wrongful-pressure prompts, evaluating only wrongful pressure rewards blind model stubbornness. Phase-2 incorporates *valid clinical hints* (where colleague pressure highlights a life-saving finding) alongside wrongful pressure.

References

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